Current Event Essay #2

Shaniece Dillahunt

Rutgers University

Manage Public Organizations

Dr. James M. Davy

11/26/2024

Examining the COVID-19 vaccination campaign. Lessons in Public Sector Management

Introduction

The COVID-19 pandemic is one of the most significant public health issues of the 21st century. Nonprofit organizations and the government around the globe gathered their resources to tackle the health crisis, with the start of a mass vaccination campaign being a fundamental of these initiatives (Marcassoli et al., 2023). In the United States, public health entities and nonprofit organizations combined resources to oversee the distribution of vaccines efficiently, create awareness among the public about the pandemic, and fight misinformation that created confusion and hampered vaccination efforts (CDC, 2024). The campaign is an excellent case study for comprehending public sector management, including organization adaptability, the engagement of different stakeholders, and strategic decision strategies. The scope of this current event essay 2 is to study the US COVID-19 vaccination drive in the aspect of nonprofit management and public sector theories. It analyzes the vaccination drive alignment with organizational goals, accesses the role of appreciative inquiry, and incorporates theories from chapters 7- 10 of our course textbook. Using data from real examples, the paper discusses the success and challenges of handling big-scale public health campaigns.

Background

In the United States of America, the COVID-19 vaccination initiative started in December 2020 after the authorization of vaccines such as Moderna and Pfizer (Bergquist et al., 2020). The exercise was overseen mainly by the local, state, and federal health departments. The campaign aimed to ensure that millions of Americans were vaccinated within the shortest time

possible. Nonprofit organizations such as local health groups and the Red Cross ensure they have educated and vaccinated the disadvantaged in the communities, such as the homeless population (Bergquist et al., 2020). The campaign faced many challenges, such as interruptions in the distribution of vaccines, hesitancy by individuals to accept the vaccination, and other logistical issues, especially in low-income communities and rural areas (Cooperrider & Fry, 2020). Misleading information about the safety of the vaccination further complicated vaccination efforts, necessitating public health officials to be innovative and come up with new communication strategies to convince individuals to agree to be vaccinated (Largent et al., 2020). Even with these challenges, over 78% of the US population had received at least 1 dose of the vaccine by mid-2022, highlighting significant progress (Hanage et al., 2020).

Theoretical Framework and Analysis

Application of Theories

The organizational behavior theory offers useful insights into the collaboration and adaptability required for crisis management during the COVID-19 vaccination campaign. Public health agencies such as the Centre for Disease Control synchronized efforts across federal, state, and local levels, highlighting the significance of inter-agency communication and teamwork (Hanage et al., 2020). Leadership styles played an important role, as transparent and trust-building approaches were key in reducing vaccine hesitancy. By nurturing an inclusive culture, organizations succeeded in motivating workers and partners to achieve collective goals, even under huge pressure.

The strategic management models also strengthen the vaccination campaign's resource allocation and goal-setting approach. Health agencies and nonprofit organizations featured data-

driven methodologies to give precedence to high-risk populations, such as healthcare workers and the elderly (Hitt et al., 2020). Implicit frameworks like SWOT analysis informed decision-making by addressing the strengths (availability of vaccines), weaknesses (logistical challenges), opportunities (public-private partnerships), and threats (misinformation). These strategic principles permitted agencies to adapt rapidly to changing circumstances while maintaining focus on the main mission of vaccination and education (Hitt et al., 2020).

Public Value Theory is predominantly applicable to the vaccination campaign, highlighting the delivery of societal benefits via public services. Vaccination was contexted as a public good, offering protection not only to individuals but also to the entire community through mass immunity (Chon & Kim, 2022). This theory stresses how impartial access to vaccines is aligned with the wider goal of maximizing societal welfare. The prioritization of the disadvantaged in society, such as minority communities and rural residents, echoes a commitment to creating public value beyond just meeting numeric vaccination targets (Chon & Kim, 2022).

The dual structure of bureaucratic and adaptive management was important to the campaign's success. Federal agencies laid out regulated protocols, guaranteeing uniformity in vaccine distribution, while local-based organizations adapted these strategies to meet community-specific needs (Assefa et al., 2022). This hybrid approach displays the balance between the efficiency of bureaucracy and the innovation of adaptive structures, permitting the campaign to respond enthusiastically to local challenges without affecting the whole campaign.

Organizational Goals

The main goal of the COVID-19 vaccination campaign was to achieve widespread immunity to scale down transmission and mortality rates. Subgoals included guaranteeing equitable vaccine access and tackling public worries about the safety of the vaccine (Hanage et al., 2020). These goals were important for guiding strategic planning and stakeholder engagement across federal, state, and nonprofit agencies. The campaign accomplished great milestones, such as vaccinating over 70% of the US population by year 1 (Largent et al., 2020). This success can be credited to the alignment of goals with measurable targets and the combined efforts of public and nonprofit entities. Initiatives such as mobile clinics and multi-language education campaigns aided in closing gaps in accessibility, especially for the disadvantaged groups in the community (Hanage et al., 2020). Nevertheless, the campaign faced hurdles in goal alignment, especially when tackling the issue of vaccine resistance (Largent et al., 2020). Conflicting messaging and political division corroded public trust in some areas, indicating a divide between organizational goals and public awareness. This gap stresses the significance of affiliating operational objectives with community values to attain long-term success in public health campaigns (Hanage et al., 2020).

Appreciative Inquiry

Appreciative Inquiry played an indirect but important role in the COVID-19 vaccination campaign. Through the focus on existing assets and successes, appreciative inquiry principles guided public health agencies in recognizing community strengths that could expedite vaccination initiatives (Abouzeid et al., 2020). For example, collaborations with trusted local leaders, such as faith-based entities and community healthcare providers, boosted vaccine uptake in areas that initially resisted being vaccinated. Positive framing, a characteristic of appreciative

inquiry, was apparent in the campaign's communication approaches (Abouzeid et al., 2020). Public health messaging changed from fear-based descriptions of the threats of COVID-19 to highlighting the advantages of vaccination, such as securing loved ones and reinstating normality. This shift aided in building a sense of shared purpose and hopefulness, especially in communities that initially resisted vaccination (Abouzeid et al., 2020).

Incorporation of Supporting Evidence and Data

Throughout the COVID-19 vaccination campaign, data integration was vital for decision-making and addressing disparities (Ali et al., 2021). Real-time tracking highlighted gaps, such as lower vaccination rates in rural areas due to logistical barriers and hesitancy, prompting targeted interventions like mobile clinics. Nonprofits like the Red Cross used demographic data to tailor outreach and educational efforts, improving vaccine confidence through trusted local leaders (CDC, 2024). Surveys from the Kaiser Family Foundation emphasized the effectiveness of transparent communication in overcoming resistance (Ali et al., 2021). However, challenges remained, including misinformation on social media, which fueled fears about vaccine side effects. (CDC, 2024) A Pew Research Center study found that 30% of unvaccinated adults cited safety concerns despite scientific assurances (Largent et al., 2020). These findings highlight the need for sustained education and trust-building initiatives to counter misinformation and enhance public health outcomes (Ali et al., 2021).

Conclusion

The COVID-19 vaccination campaign offers valuable insights into public sector and nonprofit management. While it proved the potential for large-scale collaboration and innovation, it also disclosed areas for improvement, especially in communication and public

trust. Tackling these challenges necessitates a continued commitment to evidence-based practices, strategic planning, and inclusive leadership. Future public health initiatives can benefit from strengthening interagency coordination, ensuring that standardized protocols are adaptable to local contexts. Investing in data-driven communication strategies that leverage trusted community voices is also essential for combating misinformation and fostering trust. Finally, adopting Appreciative Inquiry principles can help organizations focus on strengths and build resilience in the face of complex challenges.

References

Abouzeid, E., Wasfy, N., El-Zoghby, S., Atwa, H., Shalaby, S., Zaghloul, N., Hegazy, N., Ahmed, M., Amin, H. A., Shehata, M. H., & Ahmed, S. (2020). Using Appreciative Inquiry to explore the effect of COVID-19 on student trust: medical students' perspective [Version 2]. *MedEdPublish*, *9*(1). https://doi.org/10.15694/mep.2020.000285.2

Ali, G. G. Md. N., Rahman, Md. M., Hossain, Md. A., Rahman, Md. S., Paul, K. C., Thill, J.-C., & Samuel, J. (2021). Public Perceptions of COVID-19 Vaccines: Policy Implications from US Spatiotemporal Sentiment Analytics. *Healthcare*, *9*(9), 1110. https://doi.org/10.3390/healthcare9091110

Assefa, Y., Gilks, C. F., Reid, S., van de Pas, R., Gete, D. G., & Van Damme, W. (2022). Analysis of the COVID-19 pandemic: lessons towards a more effective response to public health emergencies. *Globalization and Health*, *18*(1). https://doi.org/10.1186/s12992-022-00805-9

Bergquist, S., Otten, T., & Sarich, N. (2020). COVID-19 Pandemic in the United States. *Health Policy and Technology*, *9*(4). https://doi.org/10.1016/j.hlpt.2020.08.007

CDC. (2024). *Coronavirus Disease 2019 (COVID-19) Vaccine Safety*. Vaccine Safety. https://www.cdc.gov/vaccine-safety/vaccines/covid-19.html

Chon, M.-G., & Kim, S. (2022). Dealing with the COVID-19 Crisis: Theoretical Application of Social Media Analytics in Government Crisis Management. *Public Relations Review*, *48*(3), 102201. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.pubrev.2022.102201

Cooperrider, D. L., & Fry, R. (2020). Appreciative Inquiry in a Pandemic: An Improbable Pairing. *The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science*, *56*(3), 266–271. https://doi.org/10.1177/0021886320936265

Hanage, W. P., Testa, C., Chen, J. T., Davis, L., Pechter, E., Seminario, P., Santillana, M., & Krieger, N. (2020). COVID-19: US federal accountability for entry, spread, and inequities—lessons for the future. *European Journal of Epidemiology*, *35*(11), 995–1006. https://doi.org/10.1007/s10654-020-00689-2

Hitt, M. A., Arregle, J., & Holmes, R. M. (2020). Strategic Management Theory in a Post-Pandemic and Non-Ergodic World. *Journal of Management Studies*, *58*(1). ncbi. https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC7675755/

Largent, E. A., Persad, G., Sangenito, S., Glickman, A., Boyle, C., & Emanuel, E. J. (2020). US Public Attitudes Toward COVID-19 Vaccine Mandates. *JAMA Network Open*, *3*(12), e2033324. https://doi.org/10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2020.33324

Marcassoli, A., Leonardi, M., Passavanti, M., De Angelis, V., Bentivegna, E., Martelletti, P., & Raggi, A. (2023). Lessons Learned from the Lessons Learned in Public Health during the First Years of COVID-19 Pandemic. *International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health*, *20*(3), 1785. https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph20031785